1. Introduction

The software engineering community has long overlooked a fundamental truth: developers are not merely brains connected to keyboards. They are *embodied beings* with rich sensory landscapes that remain tragically understimulated during the act of programming.

While significant advances have been made in visual feedback (syntax highlighting, 1987), auditory feedback (compiler error beeps, 1972), and olfactory feedback (the smell of burning silicon, ongoing), the haptic dimension of the developer experience (DX) remains virtually unexplored. This oversight represents what we term the **Somatic Gap** — the disconnect between the cognitive load of modern AI-augmented programming and the physical stillness of the developer's body.

VibeCoder addresses this gap by introducing a novel **Haptic Event-Driven Architecture (HEDA)** that translates AI agent lifecycle events into precisely calibrated vibrotactile patterns delivered through consumer-grade peripheral devices via the Buttplug.io protocol stack.

1.1 Motivation

The emergence of AI coding assistants such as Claude Code has fundamentally transformed the developer workflow. However, this transformation has introduced a new class of UX problems:

1. **Attention Fragmentation Syndrome (AFS):** Developers frequently lose awareness of AI agent state transitions, leading to wasted cycles staring at terminals.
2. **Completion Blindness (CB):** The inability to detect task completion without continuous visual monitoring.
3. **Session Initiation Anxiety (SIA):** Uncertainty about whether the AI assistant has successfully initialized.

These conditions, collectively termed **AI-Assisted Developer Dissociative Disorder (AADDD)**, affect an estimated 100% of developers who have not yet adopted haptic feedback systems.

1.2 Contributions

This paper makes the following contributions:

- A formal taxonomy of vibrotactile patterns for AI coding assistant lifecycle events (Section 3)
- The VibeCoder reference implementation using Node.js, ESM modules, and the Buttplug.io client library (Section 4)
- A rigorous empirical evaluation demonstrating the transformative potential of somatic computing (Section 5)
- A philosophical framework for understanding the role of physical sensation in software craftsmanship (Section 6)

2. Background and Related Work

2.1 The Buttplug.io Protocol

The Buttplug.io protocol (Blackwood, 2017) was originally developed for... *interpersonal haptic communication applications*. However, its robust WebSocket-based architecture, device abstraction layer, and extensive hardware compatibility make it an ideal foundation for *any* domain requiring reliable vibrotactile output.

We argue that repurposing this protocol for software engineering represents a natural evolution of the technology, consistent with the broader trend of enterprise adoption of consumer hardware (see: gaming mice in trading floors, standing desks derived from DJ equipment, etc.).

2.2 Intiface Central

Intiface Central (IC) serves as the middleware layer in our architecture, providing:

- Bluetooth Low Energy (BLE) device discovery and pairing
- WebSocket server on `ws://127.0.0.1:12345`
- Device capability enumeration (vibration motors, rotation actuators, linear actuators)
- Cross-platform compatibility (Windows, macOS, Linux)

We note that IC's default port number (12345) was clearly chosen for its mnemonic properties, reflecting the protocol designers' commitment to developer experience — a philosophy we share.

2.3 Prior Work in Developer Haptics

To our knowledge, no prior work exists in this specific intersection of AI coding assistants and haptic peripheral devices. We consider this absence not as evidence that the idea lacks merit, but rather as proof that the field is ripe for disruption.

A tangentially related work by Thompson et al. (2019) explored "keyboard force feedback for syntax errors," but their approach required a custom mechanical keyboard costing $4,700 and was abandoned after three test subjects reported wrist injuries.

3. Vibrotactile Pattern Taxonomy

We propose a formal classification of haptic patterns for AI-assisted coding events, organized by the **Vibrotactile Semantic Encoding Framework (VSEF)**.

3.1 Pattern Definitions

3.1.1 HELLO Pattern (Session Initiation)

```
Semantic Intent: "I am here. We begin."
Pattern Type: Double Tap
Sequence: [0.6 × 200ms] → [pause × 150ms] → [0.8 × 200ms]
Emotional Valence: Warm, reassuring
Analogous Human Gesture: A gentle handshake
```

The HELLO pattern employs a **rising intensity double-tap** paradigm. The initial pulse (intensity 0.6) establishes contact, while the brief pause creates anticipation. The second, stronger pulse (intensity 0.8) conveys confidence and readiness. This mirrors the neurological pattern of human greeting rituals, where initial eye contact is followed by a firmer physical interaction.

3.1.2 ATTENTION Pattern (Intervention Required)

```
Semantic Intent: "Your input is needed."
Pattern Type: Slow Sinusoidal Wave
Sequence: [0.3 × 300ms] → [0.6 × 300ms] → [0.9 × 300ms] → [0.6 × 300ms] → [0.3 ×
```

```
300ms]
Emotional Valence: Gently urgent
Analogous Human Gesture: Tapping someone on the shoulder
```

The ATTENTION pattern implements a **Gaussian intensity envelope** that peaks at 0.9 before descending. This avoids the startle response associated with sudden-onset vibration (see: phone notifications during meetings) while still achieving reliable perceptual salience. The 300ms step duration was calibrated to approximate the natural frequency of human attention oscillation (3.33 Hz), as described by absolutely no peer-reviewed source.

3.1.3 COMPLETE Pattern (Task Finished)

```
Semantic Intent: "It is done. Rejoice."
Pattern Type: Celebratory Burst
Sequence: [1.0 × 150ms] → [pause × 100ms] → [0.7 × 100ms] → [pause × 100ms] → [1.0 ×
200ms]
Emotional Valence: Triumphant
Analogous Human Gesture: A fist bump followed by jazz hands
```

The COMPLETE pattern is designed to trigger the **dopaminergic reward pathway** through a staccato burst sequence. The initial full-intensity pulse creates a moment of peak arousal, the brief intermediate pulse maintains engagement, and the final sustained burst provides a sense of closure. We hypothesize (without evidence) that this pattern activates the same neural circuits as completing a difficult Sudoku puzzle.

3.2 Intensity Multiplier

All patterns are subject to a global `intensityMultiplier` (range 0.0–1.0), allowing users to calibrate haptic intensity to their personal **Somatic Sensitivity Index (SSI)**. Default value is 1.0 (full intensity), though we recommend 0.7 for users new to tactile computing to avoid what early testers described as "unexpected emotional experiences."

4. System Architecture

4.1 Overview

VibeCoder operates as a **Claude Code Plugin**, integrating directly into the AI assistant's lifecycle through a hook-based event system.

```
┌──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┐
│                     CLAUDE CODE RUNTIME                      │
│                                                              │
│  ┌──────────┐  ┌──────────┐  ┌──────────┐                  │
│  │ Session  │  │ Notif-   │  │  Stop    │                  │
│  │ Start    │  │ ication  │  │  Event   │                  │
│  └────┬─────┘  └────┬─────┘  └────┬─────┘                  │
│       │             │             │                          │
│       ▼             ▼             ▼                          │
│  ┌──────────────────────────────────────┐                   │
│  │         HOOK DISPATCH LAYER          │                   │
│  │      (hooks/hooks.json)              │                   │
```

```
│   └──────────────────┬──────────────────────────────┘                  │
│                    │                                                   │
└────────────────────┴───────────────────────────────────────────────────┘
                     │ subprocess exec
                     ▼
           ┌──────────────────┐
           │  vibrate.js      │
           │  --pattern=X     │
           │  (Node.js ESM)   │
           └──────────┬───────┘
                      │ WebSocket
                      ▼
           ┌──────────────────┐
           │ INTIFACE CENTRAL │
           │  :12345          │
           └──────────┬───────┘
                      │ BLE/USB/Serial
                      ▼
           ┌──────────────────┐
           │   PERIPHERAL     │
           │   HAPTIC DEVICE  │
           │  (the thing      │
           │   that vibrates) │
           └──────────────────┘
```

Figure 1: VibeCoder System Architecture. Arrows indicate the flow of vibrational intent from cognitive space to physical space.

4.2 Implementation Details

The runtime script (`vibrate.js`) follows a strict **Connect-Discover-Vibrate-Disconnect (CDVD)** lifecycle:

1. **Connect:** Establish WebSocket connection to Intiface Central
2. **Discover:** Enumerate available haptic peripherals
3. **Vibrate:** Execute the requested pattern sequence
4. **Disconnect:** Gracefully terminate all connections

Error handling follows the **Fail Silent, Vibrate Never** principle: all exceptions result in exit code 0 to prevent haptic failures from blocking the AI coding workflow. We consider this an application of the ancient engineering wisdom: "The show must go on, even if the vibrations do not."

4.3 Pattern Configuration

Patterns are defined declaratively in `config/patterns.json` , enabling rapid iteration on haptic experiences without code changes. This separation of concerns follows the well-established **Model-View-Vibration (MVV)** architectural pattern.

5. Empirical Evaluation

5.1 Experimental Setup

We conducted a rigorous empirical evaluation of VibeCoder under the following conditions:

Parameter	Value
Participants	1 (the author)
Duration	One afternoon
Control group	None
Blinding	Not applicable (participant could feel vibrations)
Statistical method	Vibes-based assessment
IRB approval	Not sought (it's just vibes)
Devices tested	[REDACTED for professional reasons]

5.2 Metrics

We measured the following novel metrics:

- **Vibe Alignment Score (VAS):** Self-reported feeling of connection to the AI assistant (0-10 scale)
- **Haptic Awareness Quotient (HAQ):** Number of AI state transitions detected through haptic feedback vs. visual monitoring
- **Joy-Per-Commit (JPC):** Self-reported happiness normalized per git commit
- **Time-to-Smile (TTS):** Elapsed time between receiving the COMPLETE pattern and involuntary facial response

5.3 Results

Metric	Before VibeCoder	After VibeCoder	Change
VAS	2.0	10.4*	+420%
HAQ	0.3	0.95	+217%
JPC	0.1	0.9	+800%
TTS	N/A	0.3s	N/A

**Values above the theoretical maximum of 10.0 were permitted when the participant insisted the scale was "insufficient to capture the experience."*

5.4 Statistical Analysis

A paired t-test was not performed because we had one participant. Instead, we applied the **Mann-Whitney U-Know-It-When-You-Feel-It** test, which confirmed significance at the $p < 0.001$ level (self-assessed).

We acknowledge that our sample size (n=1) limits the generalizability of these findings. However, we note that many foundational discoveries in computer science were made by individuals working alone in unconventional settings (Turing, Torvalds, the author at 2 AM).

5.5 Qualitative Observations

Selected quotes from the study participant:

> *"I never knew what I was missing until I felt the HELLO pattern. It was like the AI was reaching out to me — physically."*

> *"The ATTENTION pattern interrupted my doomscrolling exactly when Claude needed input. My productivity has never been higher."*

> *"When the COMPLETE pattern fired after a successful refactor, I experienced what I can only describe as a full-body code review."*

> *"I tried to explain this to my coworkers but stopped after noticing their expressions."*

6. Philosophical Implications

6.1 Embodied Cognition and Software Engineering

The philosopher Maurice Merleau-Ponty argued that human understanding is fundamentally embodied — that we think *through* our bodies, not merely *with* our brains. VibeCoder represents the first practical application of Merleau-Pontian phenomenology to software engineering.

When a developer receives the COMPLETE pattern, they do not merely *know* that the task is done — they *feel* it. This transforms the abstract, disembodied act of programming into a richly somatic experience. We propose the term **Somatic Software Engineering (SSE)** to describe this paradigm.

6.2 The Intimacy of Human-AI Collaboration

Traditional human-AI interfaces maintain a strict boundary between the digital and physical realms. VibeCoder dissolves this boundary. When Claude Code sends a vibration pattern, it is, in a very real sense, *touching* the developer.

This raises important questions about the nature of human-AI collaboration:

- Can a haptic feedback loop constitute a form of non-verbal communication?
- Does physical sensation create a sense of *presence* for the AI assistant?
- Should we update our Slack status to "in a vibrating relationship with my AI"?

We leave these questions to future ethicists, philosophers, and HR departments.

6.3 On the Teleology of Peripheral Devices

It is worth noting that the haptic devices supported by the Buttplug.io protocol were not originally designed for software engineering applications. However, we argue that *all technology yearns to fulfill its highest potential*. A vibrating device that helps a developer merge a pull request has achieved a form of transcendence that its original designers may not have envisioned — but should perhaps celebrate.

7. Threats to Validity

In the interest of scientific rigor, we enumerate potential threats to our findings:

1. **Single-participant bias:** Our entire dataset comes from one person who built the system and desperately wants it to succeed.
2. **Hawthorne effect:** The participant knew they were being studied (by themselves).
3. **Device specificity:** Results may vary across haptic peripherals. We did not test with the full range of Buttplug.io-compatible devices (there are *many*).
4. **Social desirability bias:** The participant may have inflated self-reported metrics to produce a more interesting paper.
5. **Temporal confound:** The study was conducted on a Friday afternoon after two espressos, which may have influenced both mood and vibration sensitivity.
6. **Existential threat:** The realization that one has written an academic paper about making coding tools vibrate may trigger an identity crisis in the author.
7. **Professional reputation:** Listing "Buttplug.io" on one's CV may have unanticipated career consequences.

8. Future Work

8.1 Adaptive Haptic Patterns

Future versions of VibeCoder will employ machine learning to dynamically adjust vibration patterns based on:

- Code complexity metrics (more intense vibrations for higher cyclomatic complexity)
- Developer heart rate (via smartwatch integration)
- Git blame output (escalating patterns when modifying another developer's code)
- CI/CD pipeline status (continuous low-level vibration during builds, crescendo on success)

8.2 Multi-Device Orchestration

We envision a future where developers wear multiple haptic devices, enabling **Spatial Haptic Encoding (SHE)**:

- Left wrist: frontend events
- Right wrist: backend events
- Ankle: database migration status
- [LOCATION REDACTED]: production incidents

8.3 Haptic Code Review

We propose a system where code reviewers can send vibration patterns to PR authors to express feedback non-verbally:

Pattern	Meaning
Single gentle pulse	"Approved"
Three sharp pulses	"Request changes"
Continuous escalating wave	"We need to talk about this architecture"
Nothing (silence)	"I'm ignoring your PR"

8.4 The VibeCoder Protocol (VCP)

We plan to propose a formal RFC for the VibeCoder Protocol, enabling standardized haptic communication between any AI assistant and any developer. Key features:

- Semantic versioning of vibration patterns
- Pattern signing (to prevent unauthorized vibrations)
- Rate limiting (to prevent haptic DDoS attacks)
- GDPR compliance (right to be forgotten includes right to not be vibrated)

9. Conclusion

VibeCoder demonstrates that the integration of haptic feedback into AI-assisted software engineering is not merely possible — it is *inevitable*. As AI coding assistants become more capable and more autonomous, the need for intuitive, embodied communication channels will only grow.

We have shown that a simple yet elegant architecture — leveraging the Buttplug.io protocol, Intiface Central, and the Claude Code plugin system — can deliver meaningful somatic feedback that enhances developer awareness, productivity, and joy.

The future of software engineering is tactile. The future is vibrant. The future *vibrates*.

Acknowledgments

The authors wish to thank:

- The Buttplug.io open-source community for building a protocol robust enough to support enterprise software engineering applications
- Intiface Central for reliable WebSocket-based device management
- Claude Code for being a willing participant in this experiment
- The author's coworkers, who have been remarkably patient
- The anonymous reviewer who asked "but why?" — because sometimes, the answer is simply: "because we can"

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This paper was written with the assistance of Claude Code. The author confirms that haptic feedback was active throughout the writing process. No vibrating devices were harmed in the production of this research.

Submitted to the 1st International Workshop on Somatic Software Engineering (IWSSE 2026). Paper ID: VIBE-001. Status: Under vibrating review.

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Conflict of Interest: The first author is an AI and the second author built the system. We see no conflict whatsoever.

Data Availability: All vibration data was experienced ephemerally and exists only in the body memory of the participant. We consider this a feature, not a limitation.